

Transcript Research Proposal Presentation

Welcome to my research proposal presentation about explaining the persistent gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector. This is a mixed methods research proposal, which does not aim to establish causality, but more to assess explanatory strength across to competing theories.

Let us go ahead with the research problem and significance. Why does the gender pay gap persists in Singapore's IT sector? First of all, national data from Singapore's Ministry of Manpower (MOM, 2023) and a OECD report (2024) consistently show a persistent gender pay gap within the IT sector, even after adjusting for observable characteristics such as education and work experience. Further authors like Lin et al. (2020) demonstrate that while the adjusted general pay gap has narrowed substantial unexplained components remain, particularly at senior and specialist level, which often applies in the IT sector as you need a lot of specialist roles. Ridgeway (2011) argues that wage inequality often becomes embedded within organisational hierarchies, rather than at the entry point of labour market. This is all especially significant in Singapore's IT sector, which plays a central role in the country's smart nation strategy as well as in the nation's economy, as highlighted by IMDA (2023). Despite this, current policy initiatives continue to emphasise skills development and labour supply, with comparatively limited attention to organisational power structures and promotion processes. This is also a gap noted by World Economic Forum (2023). Overall, it's very significant because you don't really utilise the female talents in the labour maket, according to Heilman (2012).

Let us continue with trying to explain the unexplained gender pay gap in Singapore. The figure in the top illustrates the distinction between the unadjusted and adjusted gender pay gap in Singapore.

While the unadjusted gender pay gap stands at 14.3%, controlling for labour market factors such as occupation, industry and working hours, as a lot of females work part time in Singapore, reduces the gap to approximately 6%, according to MOM (2023). Crucially, this indicates that human capital and observable labour market characteristics explain only a part of wage disparity, only approximately 8.3%. A substantial unexplained component remains, which is the 8.3%, which I just mentioned, which supports arguments advanced by Ridgeway (2011) and other authors that organisational and structural mechanisms, rather than individual characteristics alone, play a significant role in sustaining gender pay inequality, particularly at higher occupational levels.

Overall, to sum it up, even after controlling for education and experience, a

substantial proportion of the gender pay gap remains unexplained, suggesting that factors beyond human capital such as organisational structure, require investigation.

Let us follow up with my research question. Building on the identified research problem, this study is guided by a central research question that prioritised organisational and structural explanations for pay inequality. Specifically my research question is to what extent such inequalities explain the persistent gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector beyond human capital, factors such as education and experience.

I have 3 sub supporting questions which further allow this research study to unpack by examining occupational segregation, organisational promotion practises, and the limits of human capital explanation. Together those four questions enable a structured comparison between competing theoretical perspective.

Primarily, I focus on human capital theory as proposed by Becker (1993), and gender inequality theory as articulated by Ridgeway (2011).

The overall aim of This study is to critically evaluate competing explanations for the gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector, with particularly emphasis on organisational and structural inequalities.

To achieve days 4 objectives are proposed by me.

First, the study will analyse secondary quantitative data from the Ministry of Manpower (2023) and the OECD (2024) to identify gendered wage patterns across IT roles.

2nd organisational and policy documents will be examined to identify structural and cultural barriers influencing pay progression.

3rd the study will critically assess the explanatory power of human capital theory in comparison to gender inequality theory.

And finally, the findings will be used to identify implications for both policy development and organisational practise. All those four objectives are, of course supported by respective research, as shown in their respective objectives.

So let us first of all compare the two competing explanations of the gender pay gap, which are named the human Capital Theory (HCT) by Becker (1993) and the gender inequality theory (GIT) by Ridgeway (2011).

Human capital theory attributes wage differences to variations in education, experience and skills and remains highly influential in economic policy.

However, further research shows that even after accounting for these factors, as we saw it on previous slides, substantial wage gaps persist, particularly at specialist or senior level.

In contrast, gender inequality theory, by Ridgeway (2011), emphasises how

organisational structures, cultural norms and power relation, systematically disadvantage women over time.

Supporting evidence from Ibarra et al. (2012) highlights the role of informal sponsorship and promotion practises, while Heilman (2012) demonstrates how gender stereotypes influence performance evaluation.

Taken all together, the literature suggests that organisational mechanisms provide a more robust explanation for persistent pay gaps in Singapore's IT sector, justifying their prioritisation in this study.

I will exclude the following factors on purpose. Individual career choice narratives.

Intersectionality beyond gender, for example, ethnicity, micro level, salary negotiation behaviour and also cross country comparisons.

Overall, this research does not attempt to establish causal relationships, but instead evaluates the relative explanatory power of competing theories.

My research proposal adopts a mixed methods research in order to address limitations identified in existing research on Gender Pay Gap in Singapore's IT sector. As Creswell et al. (2006) and Brown & Clarke (2006) argue, mixed methods are particularly valuable when competing theoretical explanations need to be assessed using different forms of evidence.

The quantitative component involves secondary analysis of publicly available wage and employment data sets from the Ministry of Manpower (MOM, 2023) and OECD (2024). And also descriptive and comparative analysis will be used to explain gender differences across IT occupations and seniority levels.

To complete this I will also use qualitative components which will employ thematic analysis, following Brown & Clarke (2006) to examine organisational and policy documents. This allows overall the study to identify structural and cultural mechanisms such as promotion practises and role allocation, which are not visible in aggregated wage statistics. Overall, the integration of both components enables triangulation and supports a critical comparison between human capital and organisational explanations.

Overall, this study does not involve primary data collection or direct engagement with human participants. Instead, it relies exclusively on secondary analysis of publicly available and anonymized data sets, including labour market statistics and policy documents. Those are all published by recognised institutions such as the Ministry of Manpower from Singapore and as a result, the ethical risk associated with the research is very low, as no personal, sensitive or identifiable data will be collected, stored or analysed. This methodical approach aligns with institutional ethical approval requirements and is consistent with the best practise guidance for mixed method research as outlined by Creswell et al. (2006) and Brown & Clarke (2006).

Let me describe the artefacts. The primary artefact produced by the study is a structured research proposal that outlines a mixed method approach to analyse the gender pay gap in Singapore IT sector.

Rather than developing a technical system or a software application, the contribution of this research lies in its analytical and conceptual design. Supporting outputs include a synthesised analysis of wage data and a thematic framework identifying organisational mechanisms influencing pay progression. Together, these outputs provide a foundation for future empirical research and offer evidence based insights relevant to policy makers and organisational decision makers.

For scope clarification there will be no technical or software artefact proposed and the focus is purely on analytical and conceptual contribution.

The shown timeline outlines a realistic sequence of activities designed to support the proposed mixed message methods research. The project begins in month one with finalising the research design and confirming relevant data sources and goes in probably four to five months until the report and dissemination can be published. The staged approach ensures both methodical rigour and feasibility within a good project time frame.

In conclusion, this research proposal contributes to existing literature by advancing a theoretical grounded and context specific analysis of the gender pay gap in Singapore's IT sector.

Rather than treating explanatory factors as equal, it prioritises organisational and structural mechanisms, offering a clearer explanation for persistent wage disparities beyond labour market entry. The proposed mixed methods research is appropriate given the research question, as it enables a structured comparison between competing theoretical explanations, while also remaining feasible and ethically robust within a MSc timeframe. Triangulation across quantitative data and qualitative documents strengthen the validity of the analysis, however, the study also has limitations. The absence of primary data restricts insight into firm level decision making and reliance on published narratives may limit the depth of this research. This is because of, payment being a very risky and ethical challenging topic to get primary data. Overall, these limitations also highlight opportunities for further research. In a full Masters project, for example, the proposed framework could be scaled to include interviews, organisational case studies or also intercompany data to enable a deeper examination of promotion practises and pay-setting processes in the IT sector of Singapore.

Finally, here are my references. Thank you all for listening to my research proposal.

Wordcount: 1562

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